

Problem

Paws Out is an online pet retailer specializing in mid-range pet goods. Internal data shows that 76% of website visitors who add an item to their cart do not ultimately complete a purchase—a rate 6% higher than the average cart abandonment rate. This indicates a high degree of potential lost revenue, and substantial opportunity to improve conversion rates. Our goal is to identify the factors contributing to cart abandonment by conducting focus groups with 50 website visitors

Research Methods

- **Participant Recruitment**

- Users who added items to their cart but did not complete a purchase were identified, and received a link to a screening survey via email. Screening survey questions focused on collecting demographic information including age, race, gender, location, profession, and income; respondents were offered a discount code in exchange for completing the survey. A total of 1,489 respondents completed the screening survey.
- 50 focus group participants were recruited from the survey respondents; sampling was stratified based on income (low, middle, high) and shopping modality (web vs. mobile) to group consumers who may experience different pain points impacting purchase completion (e.g., price of items, site navigation difficulties, etc.).

- **Focus Groups**

- Focus groups were selected because they offer several benefits. Their social dimensions facilitate an exchange of ideas that can generate novel insights, and providing opportunities for users to agree/disagree regarding their experiences is helpful in identifying pain points that affect all customers versus only specific customer segments in ways that may not be made as explicit in one-on-one interviews.
- Focus groups lasted 60-90 minutes, covered 12 questions regarding online shopping behaviors, and were composed of 8-10 participants.
- Existing data on cart abandonment highlights browsing behaviors, technical difficulties, additional costs/fees at checkout, and security concerns as key drivers of cart abandonment. As such, questions focused heavily on user experiences in these areas.
 - **Ex:** Can you walk us through the last time you added something to your cart but didn't complete the purchase?
 - **Ex:** Were there any specific concerns or hesitations when you reached the checkout page?

APPENDIX - RESEARCH METHODS

Cart Abandonment Statistics

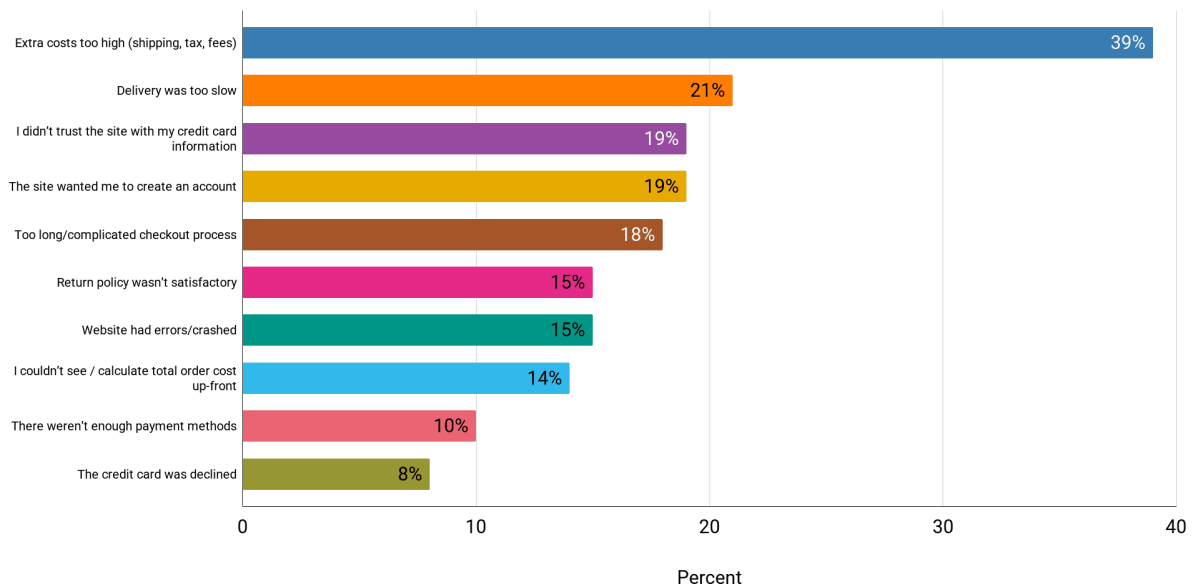
<https://baymard.com/lists/cart-abandonment-rate>

<https://baymard.com/research/checkout-usability>

- Average cart abandonment rate in 2025 was 70.19%
- Reasons for abandonment vary: 43% of cart abandoners reported using the cart as part of their browsing, when they were not truly ready to make a purchase
- Among the other 57% of online shoppers who engaged in cart abandonment, reasons for abandonment varied.

Reasons for Abandonments During Checkout

1,026 respondents | United States | General population ecommerce shoppers in the past 3 months | © 2025 baymard.com/research



- Better checkout design has been highlighted as one of the key ways ecommerce sites can improve conversion rates.

Focus Group Questions

1. How do you usually decide whether or not to buy an item online?
2. Can you walk us through the last time you added something to your cart but didn't complete the purchase?
3. Were you planning to buy immediately, or just browsing/researching?
4. What made you decide not to follow through with the purchase?
5. Were there any specific concerns or hesitations when you reached the checkout page?
6. Were there any unexpected costs (like shipping, taxes, or fees) at checkout that influenced your decision not to purchase?
7. Were there any parts of the shopping or checkout process that felt confusing or frustrating?
8. Did you experience any technical issues (e.g., slow loading, error messages, lost cart items)? If so, what?
9. What makes you decide to add an item to your cart?
10. Can you describe the last time you completed a purchase when you had initially intended to only browse? What made you decide to complete the purchase?

Expected Findings

Through hypothetical interviews with three representative users — Jonathan Silva, Sophia Adams, and Emma Patel — we uncovered a range of checkout-related barriers shaped by their broader work habits, digital environments, and personal identities. Each user operates within a distinct context, yet recurring themes emerged around platform overload, a lack of transparency, and limited personalization options — all of which contribute to cart abandonment.

Jonathan Silva: Cognitive Fatigue and Lack of Inclusive UX

As a 32-year-old Black non-binary account manager constantly toggling between digital tools, Jonathan experiences frequent context-switching fatigue. He typically shops online during breaks but struggles to maintain focus long enough to complete purchases. He explained that checkout interfaces often feel too dense or visually overwhelming, mirroring the clutter he faces in his work dashboards.

Jonathan's experience is further complicated by a sense of digital alienation: many e-commerce platforms fail to offer inclusive naming and pronoun options, leaving him feeling unseen. When shopping environments do not affirm his identity or feel needlessly complex, he's likely to disengage before finalizing the transaction — especially when no single-click options or saved payment settings are present.

Main reasons for cart abandonment: checkout clutter, decision fatigue, lack of inclusive customization, no identity-affirming features.

Sophia Adams: Distrust and Frustration with Hidden Costs

Sophia, a 51-year-old nurse with irregular shifts, often shops online in short windows of time, relying on her phone. She expressed frustration with checkout systems that are not optimized for mobile use, and noted that she often abandons purchases when hidden costs — like shipping or service fees — appear too late in the process.

Her experience with inefficient hospital systems has heightened her sensitivity to slow, unintuitive interfaces. She avoids creating new accounts unless clearly necessary and dislikes checkout processes with too many steps or forced logins. Sophia's trust in the website declines if she can't see a clear path to purchase from the cart page. Age-related digital fluency challenges also make her wary of sites that feel overly technical or lack clear instructions.

Main reasons for cart abandonment: unclear pricing, long or confusing checkout processes, mobile interface issues, forced account creation.

Emma Patel: Lack of Continuity and Rigid Checkout Systems

Emma, a 30-year-old non-binary civil engineer, typically shops during fragmented breaks between collaborative meetings. She often adds items to her cart intending to complete the purchase later, but is frequently thwarted by lack of session memory across devices. If she starts a checkout process on her phone and tries to finish it on a laptop, she's frustrated when carts don't sync.

Emma also highlighted that many sites lack flexible payment options or don't support saved preferences. She prefers platforms that allow for payment through Apple Pay, Google Pay, or PayPal, especially when juggling work-related expenses. In addition, sites that auto-fill gendered titles or ignore her name preferences make the transaction feel impersonal, prompting her to abandon the process entirely.

Main reasons for cart abandonment: cross-device inconsistency, lack of payment flexibility, rigid or impersonal interfaces, no session-saving or checkout recall.

Synthesis and Design Implications

Across all three users, cart abandonment was not simply a matter of indecision or cost sensitivity. Instead, it stemmed from:

- Cognitive overload (Jonathan)
- Transparency and trust issues (Sophia)
- Workflow misalignment and personalization gaps (Emma)

These findings suggest that successful checkout design must:

- Minimize unnecessary friction (e.g., reduce form fields, simplify visuals)
- Offer identity-affirming and customizable interfaces
- Display transparent pricing from the start
- Ensure mobile responsiveness and cross-device continuity
- Provide inclusive payment and profile options

By aligning with the users' broader digital behaviors and emotional needs, we can reimagine checkout as a moment of ease — not interruption.

Why These Personas?

To effectively understand and represent our customer base, we created three user personas grounded in a diverse dataset of over 50 individuals. These personas were generated using structured demographic data (including age, race, gender, location, profession, and income) and developed using the HubSpot persona framework to ensure consistency and strategic alignment. Rather than aiming for general averages, we intentionally selected three individuals who capture meaningful contrasts in professional roles, life stages, and identity-based experiences. Our goal was to build representative archetypes that reflect the range of users our product or service must serve — not just demographically, but also in terms of goals, tools, responsibilities, and contextual challenges.

Jonathan Silva, a 32-year-old Black non-binary account manager based in Columbus, Ohio, exemplifies a mid-career professional working in client-facing sales. His persona brings attention to performance metrics, CRM usage, and the dual demands of acquisition and retention — common across B2B service industries. Sophia Adams, a 51-year-old white female nurse from Fresno, California, offers a very different perspective. Her persona highlights the emotional labor of healthcare, time-sensitive communication needs, and the critical role of ongoing certification. Finally, we included Emma Patel, a 30-year-old Middle Eastern non-binary civil engineer from Charlotte, North Carolina. Emma's persona adds a technical and design-centered voice, especially in contexts where sustainability, gender equity in STEM, and workflow precision shape daily work.

These personas allow us to account for more than just broad audience segmentation — they ground our understanding of real users' values, constraints, and motivations. In particular, they span a variety of industries (sales, healthcare, and engineering), job structures (team-based vs. independent), and communication preferences (formal documentation vs. real-time messaging). We also ensured that gender-diverse and racially diverse voices were present, not as outliers but as core representatives of our user base. This approach reflects a commitment to inclusion and ensures our design, marketing, and development decisions will be attuned to the lived realities of the people we aim to serve.

By anchoring our research and planning around these personas, we are better equipped to anticipate distinct needs, empathize with users at different stages of their careers, and design tools or services that resonate across multiple dimensions of identity and work. These personas will directly inform feature prioritization, communication tone, and user journey mapping across the product lifecycle.



EMMA



Age: 32 years	Income: \$105,000
Gender: Woman	Education: Graduate
Marital status Married	Occupation: Account Manager

BIOGRAPHY

Emma is a busy professional who values her pet as a part of her family. She enjoys pampering her pet with high-end, eco-conscious products and wants the best for their health and well-being.

SHOPPING HABITS

Emma shops for pet products online because it fits better into her busy schedule. She makes frequent purchases because she likes to spoil her pets.

PETS

3 domestic shorthair cats



GOALS

- Purchase high-quality, eco-conscious pet products
- Access specs, reviews, and delivery info clearly
- Sync carts between mobile and desktop

PAIN POINTS

- Cart contents didn't sync across devices
- Product pages lacked technical detail (dimensions, ingredients)
- No PayPal option

QUOTE

“I had to rebuild my cart twice. By then, I’d lost interest.”

DEVICES



MOBILE



TABLET



PC



SOPHIA



Age: 51 years	Income: \$92,000
Gender: Woman	Education: Associate
Marital status: Single	Occupation: Nurse

BIOGRAPHY

Sophia manages long hospital shifts, and owns one senior dog and a parakeet. She values time with her pets as a way to de-stress after long days.

SHOPPING HABITS

Sophia primarily shops on her phone in between work duties. She prioritizes purchasing from sites that cater to a wide range of pets.

PETS

1 senior dog and 1 bird



GOALS

- Purchase diverse pet products
- Find user-friendly sites that save time
- Avoid financial surprises or return hassles

PAIN POINTS

- Checkout required account registration she didn't want
- Hidden fees (shipping, tax) appear at last stage
- Unclear return policies
- Website was slow on mobile

QUOTE

“I don't have time to dig through five pages just to see my total.”

DEVICES



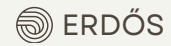
MOBILE



PC



JONATHAN



Age: 45 years	Income: \$68,000
Gender: Man	Education: Graduate
Marital status: Divorced	Occupation: Financial Analyst

BIOGRAPHY

David is a divorced man who recently adopted a rescue pit bull named Rocky. He works long hours in finance but prioritizes his time with his beloved pet. He enjoys spending weekends at the dog park.

SHOPPING HABITS

David routinely shops online for basic pet supplies, as well as toys and gear for outdoor adventures with his dog.

PETS

1 rescue pit bull



GOALS

- Support rescue pet care
- Balance price and value
- Shop quickly and efficiently

PAIN POINTS

- Checkout page lacks express pay (Apple Pay, Google Pay)
- Shipping costs not available until final screen

QUOTE

“If I can’t check out in under a minute, it’s not happening.”

DEVICES



MOBILE

1. Scenario

This is the journey of a

Streamliner

Streamliners are time-strapped professionals who value clarity, speed, and practicality. They want systems that reduce friction and help them get things done quickly, especially when under pressure.

They are highly sensitive to inefficiencies because their daily responsibilities demand precision, focus, and urgency. Streamliners value digital experiences that are clear, dependable, and built for life on the go.

Key goals and needs

- Get things done quickly
- Avoid unnecessary steps
- Mobile use optimization

Key pains and constraints

- Hidden costs
- Time is limited
- Checkout process is unclear

Context

A significant portion of Paws Out's traffic comes from mobile users shopping in short bursts during busy moments, such as work breaks or while multitasking at home. These shoppers expect a fast, intuitive experience. However, confusing checkout flows and surprise costs may be driving them away. Our research explores how these pain points impact trust and conversion.

2. Storyboard – Meet Sophia

Finally. I've got 10 minutes, let's get Buddy a new toy.

"I look for clear pricing, fast shipping, and whether it's something I really need. If I'm on a break at work, I don't have time to dig around—I just want to see the price and hit buy if it looks good."

Ugh, I don't have time to make an account

"I didn't want to go through another sign-up process. And the form fields were so tiny on my phone... it just felt like too much work for a chew toy."

"I had to zoom in to type, and the buttons didn't always respond. It wasn't clear what step I was on either. It felt like it dragged on and on."

Why didn't they show this up front? Forget it, maybe I'll try later.

Intent A Short Break to Get Things Done		Discovery Quick Win - The Right Toy, Right Away		Journey Friction - Login Letdown		Journey Friction - Endless Checkout		Conclusion Page Abandoned, Trust Gone	
When every minute counts, so does a smooth mobile experience.		We want to take advantage of consumer aha moments on our site and provide a fast experience while they have that feeling.		Forced logins and poor mobile design create mental fatigue and increase dropout risk.		Cluttered layouts and unclear steps make the mobile checkout experience feel overwhelming and time-consuming.		When total costs aren't transparent upfront, customers feel misled leading to frustration, cart abandonment, and lost brand loyalty.	
Introduction	Sophia is a 51-year-old nurse who often shops online in short windows of time during her shifts, relying on her phone.	Decision Driver	Strong reviews and fast shipping catch Sophia's attention.	Pain Points	Sophia is squinting at her screen . She has to create an account , which she doesn't have the time for but reluctantly does anyway.	Pain Points	It's tough to see what she's doing during the checkout steps, having to zoom and fumble with the screen. Her time is almost out and she's not sure how close she is to finalizing the purchase.	Pain Point	Sophia finds an extra \$9 in hidden fees when she finally makes it to the end of the checkout.
Reflection	Speed and simplicity will be essential to her to get what she needs done.	Reflection	How can we capitalize on these customer moments?	Reflection	How can we increase conversion for consumers like Sophia? Is account creation/login worth the friction?	Reflection	How can we streamline our checkout experience?	Reflection	Are we being transparent enough about total costs early in the checkout process to build trust and reduce abandonment?
		Potential Solutions	• Incorporate a 1-click purchase option • Add urgency cues to product pages	Potential Solutions	• Offer a Guest Checkout option and ensure it's easy to find on the Checkout screen • Improve the mobile responsiveness • Make larger tap targets on mobile	Potential Solutions	• Add a progress bar to clearly show where users are in the checkout process • Add auto-fill support for form fields • Design a mobile-first checkout layout • Make the checkout experience one page • Improve page load speeds	Potential Solutions	• Display estimated total cost (with shipping & taxes) on the product and/or cart pages • Add a Price Breakdown preview page before users enter checkout [Cart > Preview > Finalize Checkout] • Add a shipping cost calculator on product pages • Clearly label additional fees